

The Rwanda Expat Survival Cheat-Sheet

Everyday Kinyarwanda for markets, moto-taxis, and renting — so you stop paying the **Umuzungu tax** the moment you open your mouth.

A. Market Bargaining

Kimironko & open-air stalls

Say this	Kinyarwanda	Pro-tip
"How much is this?"	Ni bangahe? / Angahe?	Point at the item as you say it — signals you're not a first-timer, which lowers the opening price.
"Reduce the price!"	Gabanya!	The single most useful word in the book. Say it with a smile, not a demand.
"That's too expensive."	Birahenda	Use for goods — fruit, clothing, souvenirs.
"I want this one."	Ndashaka iyi	Skip the full sentence — pointing plus this phrase gets you served faster.

B. Moto-Taxis & Services

Negotiate before the ride starts

Say this	Kinyarwanda	Pro-tip
"You're overcharging!"	Urahenda	For services, not goods — e.g. a moto driver quoting 2,000 RWF for a 500 RWF trip.
"Excuse me / make way"	Ndasaba inzira	Useful in crowded spots like Nyabugogo bus park or busy market lanes.
"No problem"	Nta kibazo	The standard, friendly reply when a driver proposes a small adjustment.

C. Renting & Real Estate

Protect yourself before you sign

Say this	Kinyarwanda	Pro-tip
Tenancy agreement	Amasezerano y'Ubukode bw'Inzu	Never rent on a verbal agreement — always ask for this written document.
Landlord / owner	Nyiri inzu	The person with actual authority to move on price — confirm you're negotiating with them, not an agent.
Water & electricity	Amazi n'amashanyarazi	Always clarify whether these are included in the monthly rent before you agree to a figure.

Security deposit	Avansi	Standard is 1–3 months. Photograph the house condition before you pay it.
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